

The Washington Post

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RE V1 V2 V3 V4



Mostly sunny 67/48 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 65/46 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 22, 2025 • \$4

Plans for a new Putin summit are called off

Trump doesn't want a 'wasted meeting' after Russia spurns peace deal

BY ROBYN DIXON,
JOHN HUDSON AND
MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

President Donald Trump said Tuesday that he will not meet Russian President Vladimir Putin in the immediate future, declaring that he didn't want to have a "wasted meeting" after saying a few days ago that he would soon meet his Russian counterpart in Hungary.

The abrupt postponement appeared to be a blow to Trump's efforts to wrestle Ukraine and Russia into a ceasefire and peace deal, after a phone call with Putin and a meeting with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky made clear that the warring sides remained far apart.

Trump's acknowledgment of the scrapped meeting came hours after Russia's top diplomat signaled a wide chasm between Moscow and Washington on ending the war in Ukraine. But the president downplayed a diplomatic row between the longtime adversaries.

"I don't want to have a wasted meeting. I don't want to have a waste of time here. I'll see what happens," Trump told reporters in the Oval Office. "I said, go to the line. Go to the line of battle, the battlefield lines. And you pull back and you go home and everybody take some time off, because you've got two countries that are

SEE RUSSIA ON A12



OBTAINED BY THE WASHINGTON POST

Ongoing demolition to the East Wing of the White House in Washington on Tuesday to make way for a 90,000-square-foot ballroom.

Cries of overreach as East Wing decimated further

BY DAN DIAMOND,
JONATHAN EDWARDS,
MAUREEN LINKE
AND TIM MEKO

A demolition job that began Monday with the disappearance of the White House's eastern entrance advanced Tuesday with the destruction of much of the East Wing, according to a photograph obtained by The Washington Post and two people who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe the scene.

Photos of construction teams knocking down parts of the East

National Trust calls for construction to be halted until after public review

Wing, first revealed by The Washington Post on Monday, shocked preservationists, raised questions about White House overreach and lack of transparency, and sparked complaints from Democrats that President Donald Trump was damaging "the People's House" to pursue a personal priority.

"They're wrecking it," said Martha Joynt Kumar, a political scientist and professor emeritus at Towson University in Maryland. "And these are changes that can't be undone. They're destroying that history forever."

A White House spokesman said that the "entirety" of the East Wing would eventually be "modernized and rebuilt."

The National Trust for Historic Preservation, a nonprofit created by Congress to help preserve historic buildings, sent a letter Tuesday to administration officials, warning that the planned 90,000-

square-foot ballroom "will overwhelm the White House itself," which is about 55,000 square feet.

"We respectfully urge the Administration and the National Park Service to pause demolition until plans for the proposed ballroom go through the legally required public review processes," Carol Quillen, National Trust's CEO, said in a statement, citing two federal commissions that have traditionally reviewed White House additions.

White House officials dismissed the criticism as "manufactured."

SEE EAST WING ON A6

N.C. counties hit by Helene desperate for FEMA funds

Localities face fiscal bind with repayments delayed by new layers of red tape

BY BRADY DENNIS,
BRIANNA SACKS
AND KEVIN CROWE

Lynn Austin keeps running the numbers, and they don't look good.

Since Hurricane Helene devastated her community in western North Carolina's Blue Ridge Mountains, the county government has spent nearly \$50 million on cleanup and recovery — while getting reimbursed only \$4 million from the Federal Emergency Management Agency.

On debris removal alone, Yancey County has racked up about \$37 million in bills, with a lot more work still to do. The county's budget for the entire fiscal year: also \$37 million.

It's "a little tight," Austin, the county manager, half-joked.

More than a year after Helene, Yancey and other storm-battered counties across this region are still waiting for the federal government to make good on its promises to pay back millions upon millions of dollars that local officials have spent or allocated for recovery. The process has been agonizingly slow and unusually complicated, Austin and officials

SEE FEMA ON A4



KIYOSHI OTA/BLOOMBERG NEWS

Shattering Japan's ultimate glass ceiling

Japanese lawmakers in the lower house of parliament applaud after Sanae Takaichi, center, is elected prime minister. Takaichi is the nation's first female head of government. **Story, A9**

Vance aims to shore up a frail Gaza ceasefire

This article is by Lior Soroka, Abbie Cheeseman, Cat Zakrzewski, Gerry Shih and Karen DeYoung

TEL AVIV — Vice President JD Vance projected cautious optimism about the Trump administration's Middle East peace plans in Israel on Tuesday, downplaying a weekend of violence that threatened the fragile ceasefire in the Gaza Strip.

Vance's arrival in Israel, just a week after President Donald Trump visited, underscored the tenuousness of the ceasefire while showcasing how much external intervention will be required to keep it on track before the start of negotiations for the thornier second phase of the agreement, which aims for a permanent end to the war.

Israel and Hamas have each accused the other of violating the

Vice president arrives in Israel after blame flies over weekend violence

ceasefire amid reports of Israeli troops firing on Palestinians on a daily basis, and there remain significant disputes over the return of deceased Israeli hostages from Gaza.

Vance largely sidestepped addressing those disputes Tuesday, declining to issue a deadline for Hamas to disarm or return the bodies of the hostages. He also said the situation was evolving "better than I expected," just days after the Israeli military killed dozens of people in Gaza in strikes that it said were a re-

SEE ISRAEL ON A12

Eliza Monroe Hay is finally coming home

A retired teacher's years-long odyssey culminates in the repatriation of the 5th president's daughter

BY GREGORY S. SCHNEIDER

Barbara VornDick pulled the yellowed letter out of a gray archival box and felt a shock at what she saw. It was as if the writer had been bottled up for 180 years and was suddenly reaching out to her, a retired schoolteacher, appealing for help.

"I am now in distress, in ill health, & in a foreign [sic] country," read the frantic scrawl. Eliza

Monroe Hay, eldest daughter of President James Monroe, was stranded in Paris in 1839 and desperate for aid to "save me from utter ruin."

VornDick struggled to make sense of it. She had come to the archives at William & Mary for what she thought would be a fun research project, creating an information sheet about Eliza to help other tour guides at the historic home where VornDick worked part time.

Most history books dismiss Eliza Monroe Hay in a few lines, labeling her an arrogant woman who abandoned her family and country late in life. VornDick realized this letter and one other — apparently overlooked for all those years — suggested a new narrative.

Eliza's words said she was the victim of a swindle, with dark accusations about a close family member. Weeks after writing, Eliza — a daughter of the United

States' fifth president who had hosted dinners at the White House and been best friends with the queen of Holland — would be dead and buried in an unmarked grave in Paris's Père Lachaise cemetery.

VornDick, who spent 30 years teaching elementary school and had just moved across central Virginia to be near one of her daughters, decided on the spot that she was going to find out

SEE MONROE ON A15



MICHAEL S. WILLIAMSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

A portrait of Eliza Monroe Hay, the eldest daughter of President James Monroe, at the Highland historic site in Virginia.

IN THE NEWS

Pounding the pavement Each day the shutdown continues, ultramarathoner Rob Perez adds a mile to his route. He's now over 20 miles a day, and counting. Will he last? **B13**

Time for tip-off As the Wizards start the season, securing a prime spot in next year's NBA draft lottery could become a goal. **B7**

THE NATION

The White House is seeking to move a special-education program to a different agency. **A2**
North Carolina moved closer to drawing another safely Republican U.S. House district. **A5**

THE WORLD

Russian forces' surrender to a robot in a June operation demonstrates how land-based drones, like their aerial counterparts, are transforming battlefield tactics in Ukraine. **A8**

THE ECONOMY

Warner Bros. Discovery, parent of CNN and HBO, announced that it is open to a sale, leaving its news and streaming futures uncertain. **A14**

STYLE

Scream Clubs in D.C. and other cities offer a new, ringing opportunity to blow off steam. **B1**

SPORTS

One rule at a time, ex-NFL official Mike Pereira has become a star in broadcasting. **B7**

THE REGION

A former National Security Council staffer, who has been charged under the Espionage Act, denied leaking to China in a hearing. **B13**

D.C.'s renegade ride-hailing service, Empower, keeps on running despite legal problems. **B13**

FOOD

Hosting a dinner party inspired by Martha Stewart's 1982 book, "Entertaining," proved to be both exhausting and exhilarating. **E1**

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